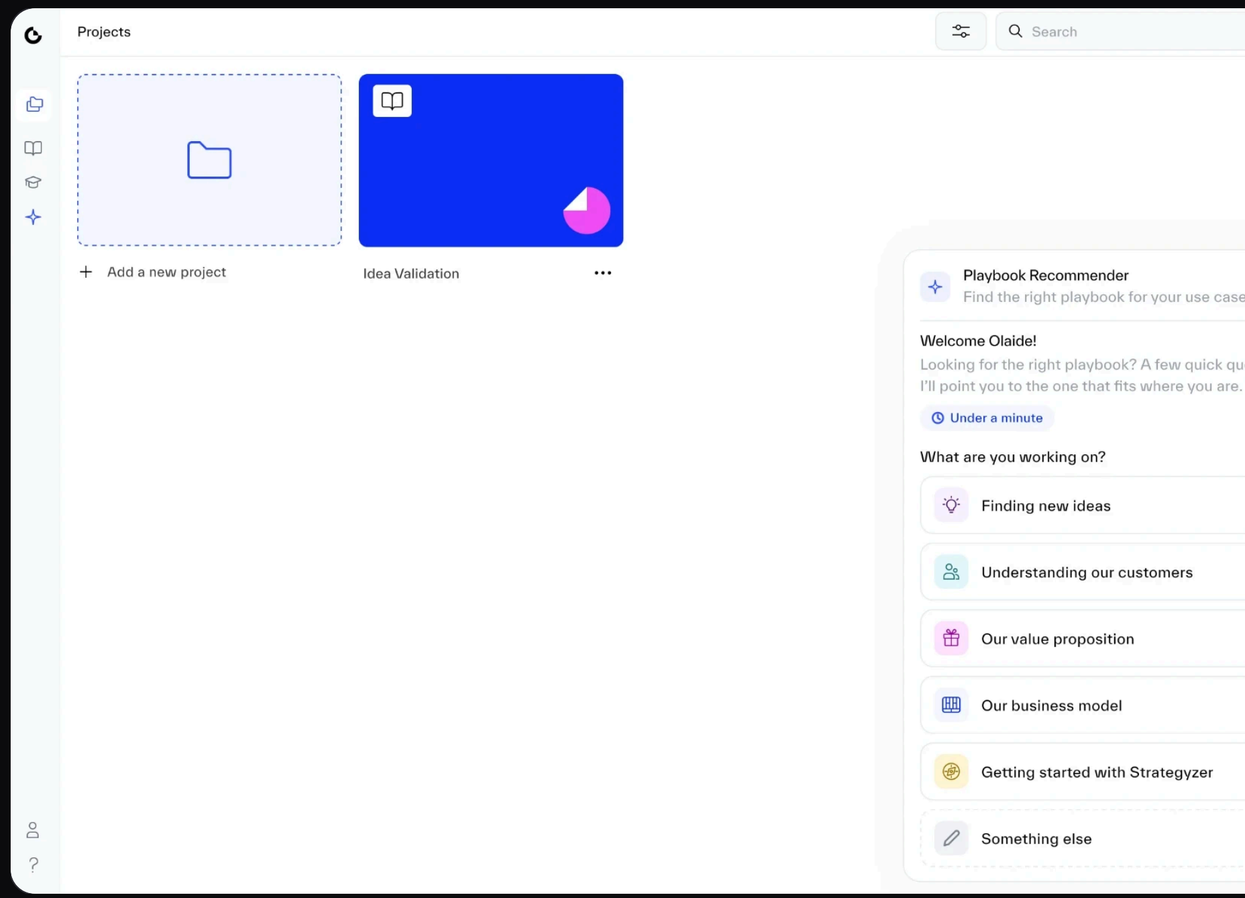
OLAIDE ARIKE KAFFO · STRATEGYZER CASE STUDY

Solving the first-step problem

We set out to build an AI assistant. I made the case to ship a three-question Playbook Recommender first.

57% → 85%

of new customers now start a project and a playbook



ROLE	TEAM	TIMELINE	STATUS
Senior product designer, and the only designer	Head of Product, one engineer, coaching and customer teams	About 6 weeks, spring 2026	Live

01 · TITLE

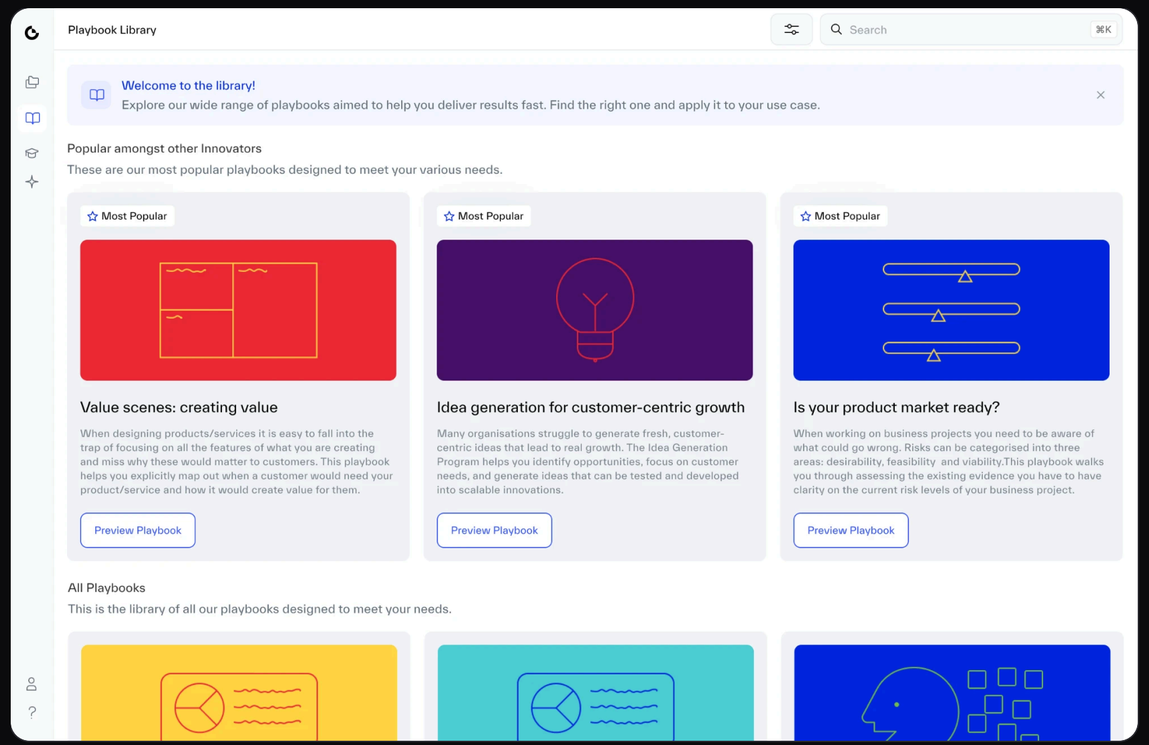
I was the only designer on this, and I led it end to end, from research and strategy to design and the front-end build. I worked with our Head of Product and one engineer, with input from our coaching and customer teams. It took about six weeks in spring 2026, and it's live. The short version is that we set out to build an AI assistant, and I made the case to ship a three-question Playbook Recommender first. New customers starting a project and a playbook went from 57% to 85%.

New customers got stuck on their first choice.

43%

of new customers never started a project.

ENTERPRISE	A coach asks two or three questions, then says start here.
SELF-SERVE	The full library, chosen alone, just when they know the least.



What a self-serve customer saw first. Long descriptions, then the whole library.

02 · PROBLEM · THE PROBLEM

About 43% of new customers never started a project. They came with a real business problem, found a library of playbooks, and couldn't tell which one was right for them. Each playbook takes hours, like running customer interviews or testing a price, so picking the wrong one wastes that time. People hesitated, guessed or gave up. For Strategyzer this was the costliest place to lose people. If nobody starts a playbook, nobody gets value, and every number from sign-up to renewal depends on that first step. How people found their first playbook depended on the kind of customer they were. Enterprise customers had a coach who asked two or three questions and said start here. Self-serve customers got the whole library and chose alone, just when they knew the least.

Even our own coaches found choosing a playbook hard.

It was the most common complaint in every conversation. So the problem was in the product.

8

customer interviews, plus our customer success and coaching teams

GROUP ONE

Solo founders

Testing an idea before pitching investors

GROUP TWO

Heads of strategy and innovation

Testing an idea before presenting to senior leaders

THE SAME PROBLEM

- Too many ideas
- No clear first step
- An important meeting coming up

03 · PROBLEM · RESEARCH

I interviewed eight customers, plus our customer success and coaching teams. They fell into two groups. Solo founders were testing an idea before pitching investors, and were new to Strategyzer's terms. Heads of strategy and innovation were testing an idea before presenting to senior leaders, often with half the work already done. Very different people with the same problem. Too many ideas, no clear first step, and an important meeting coming up. In every conversation, the most common complaint was choosing a playbook, and even our own coaches said it. If our coaches found it hard, the problem was in the product. Returning customers faced the same choice every time they started something new.

Customers were asking for AI, so we started there.

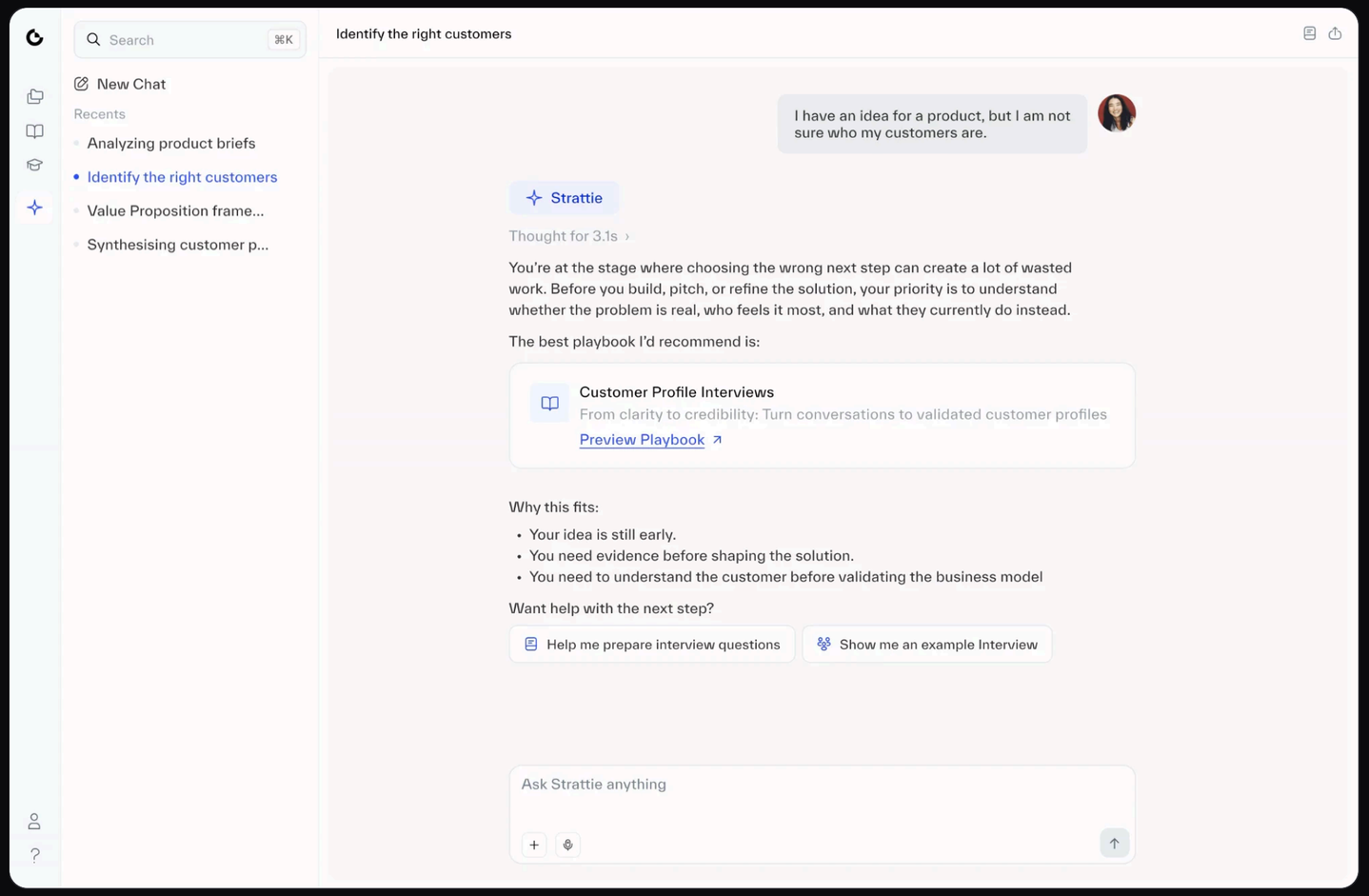
STRATTIE AI

An assistant across the whole platform, like a Strategyzer coach beside you. I designed it and built a working prototype with Claude.

A coach you could chat with

Help on the canvas

Playbook recommendations, one job of many



The full assistant, fully prototyped. Not in the first release.

04 · DECISION · THE FIRST BET

Customers were asking for AI, so we started there. The first idea was ambitious. Strattie AI was an assistant across the whole platform, like having a Strategyzer coach beside you at every step. I designed it and built a working prototype with Claude, using FondUI, our design system. It could chat as a coach on every page, help on the canvas by summarising work, pointing to evidence, checking ideas and drafting sticky notes, and recommend playbooks as one of its many jobs. The video goes from "I'm not sure who my customers are" to a finished workspace. It's fully prototyped, but it wasn't in the first release.

Chat was the wrong tool for "where do I start?"

01

The value was in the questions.

A good coach asks two or three first. The open chat often answered before asking.

02

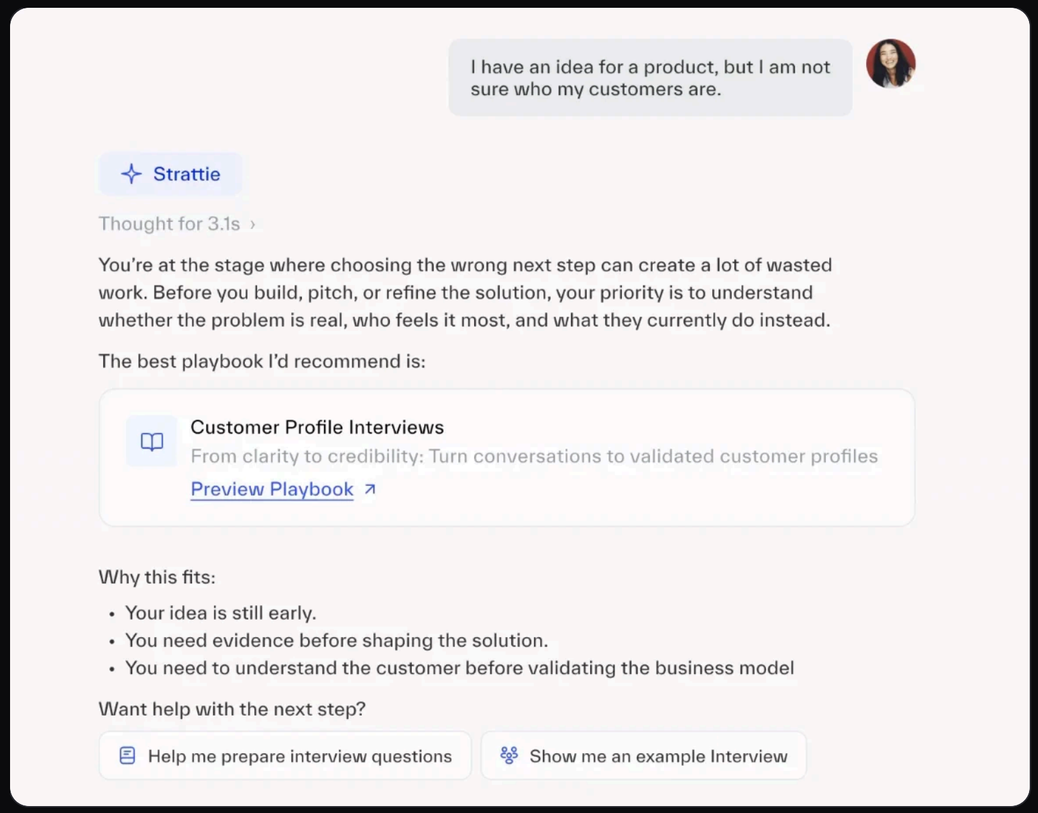
Doing it well was a much bigger job.

More than our small team could take on at the time.

03

People couldn't put their problem into words.

A chat box asks them to do exactly that.



The prototype. One message in, and it already recommends a playbook.

05 · DECISION · WHAT THE PROTOTYPE TAUGHT US

Building it for real taught us three things a static design would have hidden. First, the value was in the questions. A good coach asks two or three questions before recommending anything. In an open chat, the assistant often answered before it had asked them, and you can see it here, where one message is enough for it to recommend a playbook. Second, doing it well was a much bigger job than it looked. Vague requests, a changing library and knowing when to say "I don't know" were more than our small team could take on at the time. Third, chat is the wrong tool for "where do I start?". People came to us because they couldn't put their problem into words, and a chat box asks them to do exactly that.

Engineering couldn't build the full assistant in time. The team's first instinct, a fair one, was a smaller version of it.

I pushed back. A smaller chatbot is just a worse chatbot.

	SMALLER CHATBOT	GUIDED RECOMMENDER
Designing the conversation	Still needed in full	■ A few fixed questions
Recommending playbooks that don't exist	Still possible	■ Not possible
Describing the problem	People have to type it	■ People pick from options
Shows whether guidance helps	Not clearly	■ Yes

06 · DECISION · THE PUSHBACK

Engineering couldn't build the full assistant in the time we needed. The team's first instinct was a smaller chatbot, and that was a fair instinct. I pushed back, because a smaller chatbot is just a worse chatbot. We'd still have to design the whole conversation. It could still recommend playbooks that don't exist. People would still have to type a problem they couldn't put into words. And it wouldn't clearly tell us whether guidance helps. A few fixed questions solve all four.

SO I CHANGED THE QUESTION

~~What's the smallest assistant we can build?~~

What's the one job that matters most right now?

Every time, the answer was finding the right playbook.

MADE THE CASE TO

Our CEO and Head of Product, with the working prototype and my research.

THE PUSHBACK

Customers wanted AI. Guided questions could look like falling behind.

MY ANSWER

If people get stuck choosing, they'll leave before they ever see an AI feature.

DECISION **Ship the Recommender first. The assistant comes next.**

07 · DECISION · THE NEW QUESTION AND THE DECISION

So I changed the question. Of everything the assistant could do, one job came first every time, and that was finding the right playbook. It's where every new project starts, and where people kept getting stuck. I needed to convince our CEO and our Head of Product, who was keen on the assistant. On a call, I showed them the working prototype and my research. Every group we spoke to had the same need, help choosing where to start. The pushback was that customers were asking for AI, and guided questions could look like we were falling behind. My answer was that I wasn't against AI, and the platform will need it, but choosing a playbook comes first. If people get stuck there, they'll leave before they ever see an AI feature. Fix that first, and every AI feature we add later reaches people who are already getting value. The decision was to ship the Recommender first, with the assistant next.

A trade-off, made knowingly.

■ WHAT IT BOUGHT US

- Only real playbooks
  I'd rather ship one job done well than several half-done.
- Honest when nothing fits
- Three taps instead of typing
- Proof that guidance helps, first

WHAT IT COST · MOVED TO A LATER RELEASE

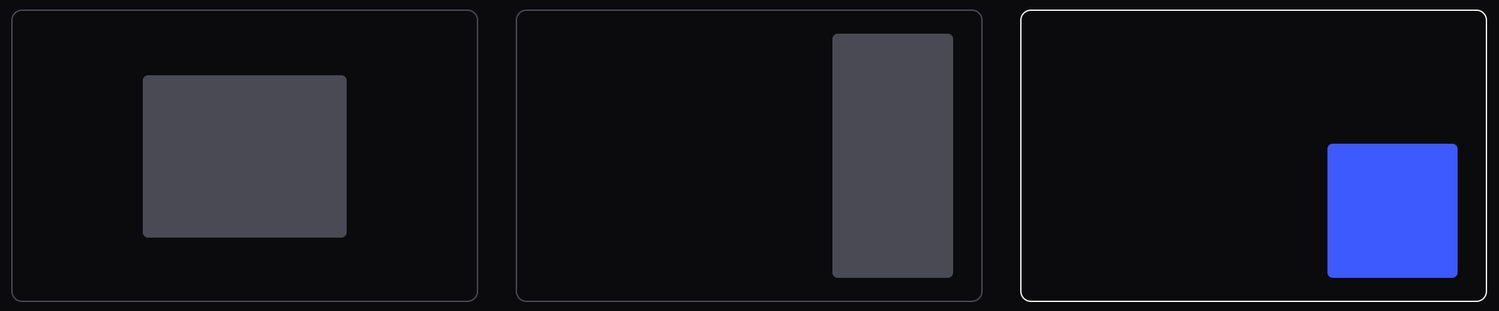
- The full assistant
- Help on the canvas
- The chat panel
- The onboarding tour

08 · DECISION · THE TRADE-OFF

It was a trade-off, and I made it knowingly. It bought us four things. It can only recommend playbooks that exist. It's honest when nothing fits, and says so instead of guessing. It takes three taps instead of explaining a problem you can't yet put into words. And it proved guidance helps before we invested in the full assistant. It cost us the full assistant, help on the canvas, which our coaches had asked for, the chat panel and the onboarding tour, all moved to a later release. That was hard to let go of. I'd rather ship one job done well than several half-done.

A small panel in the corner, built to come back to.

THREE SHAPES, TRIED AS WORKING FLOWS



Pop-up in the middle

Covered the library

Tall side panel

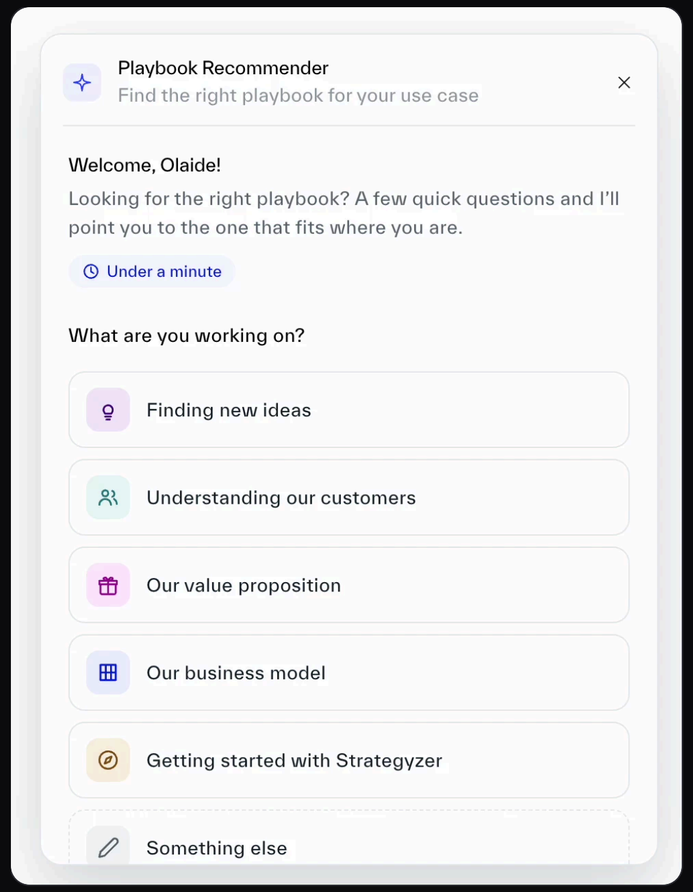
Looked like a chat that wasn't there

Small corner panel

Kept the page usable

Answers shrink as you go, so the panel stays short.

No tour. People return whenever they're stuck.



Shipped. Three questions to a recommendation.

09 · DESIGN · THE PANEL

I tried three shapes as working flows. A pop-up in the middle of the screen covered the library people were choosing from. A tall side panel looked like a chat that wasn't there. A small panel in the corner won, because it was easy to find and the page stayed usable behind it. Answers shrink as you go, a pattern borrowed from Asana's AI menu. Once you pick an answer, it shrinks to a short message and the next question appears below, so the panel stays short and easy to read. I also dropped the tour-style version I explored first, with its progress bar and big welcome screen. This is a tool people return to whenever they're stuck, so it shouldn't feel like a one-time tour.

A question map, built by hand from customer research.

5 PROBLEM AREAS → 17 GOALS → 45 PATHS → 19 PLAYBOOKS

Written down, so we can trust it and fix it when it's wrong.

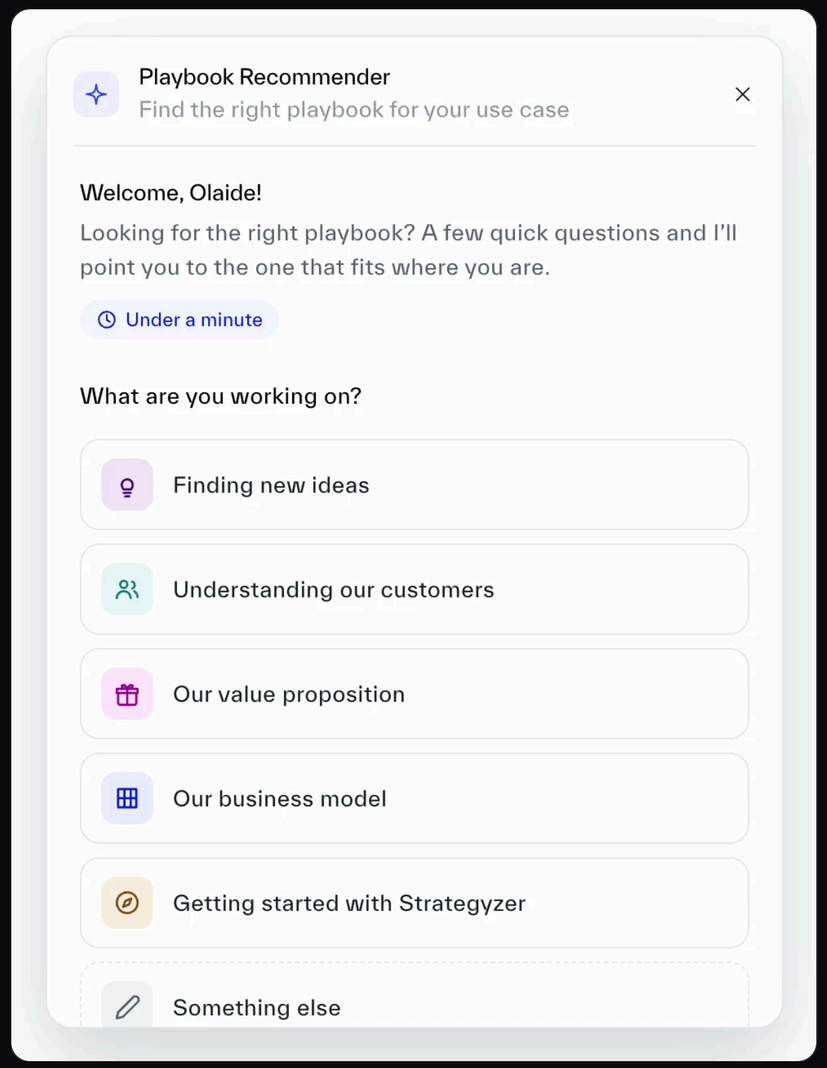
Question three only appears when it changes the answer.

IT ALSO FOUND A GAP

No playbook helped people test whether customers want their offer. The playbook team started on one straight away.

10 · DESIGN · THE QUESTION MAP

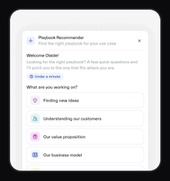
Behind the questions is a map I built in two days from how customers described their situations. It has 5 problem areas, 17 goals and 45 paths, leading to 19 playbooks. Every path is mapped by hand in a working file, with each question, its answers and the playbook it leads to. Because it's written down and not generated by AI, we can trust it and fix it when it's wrong. The questions use everyday words, so founders new to Strategyzer can answer them. Question three, "where are you now?", only appears when it changes the answer, so people with work already done can skip ahead. Mapping every need also showed a gap. Nothing helped people test whether customers want their offer, which many customers came to us needing. The Recommender says so instead of guessing, and the team that writes playbooks started on one straight away.



When nothing fits, it says so.

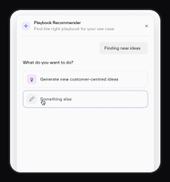
It shows the closest options instead of guessing. The hardest call in the project.

THREE MORE DETAILS THAT BUILD TRUST



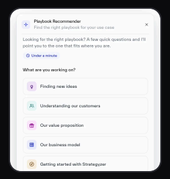
The panel stays the same size

No jumping as answers change.



Change an answer without starting over

Click any earlier answer to edit it.



"Something else" in your own words

AI finds the closest real playbooks.

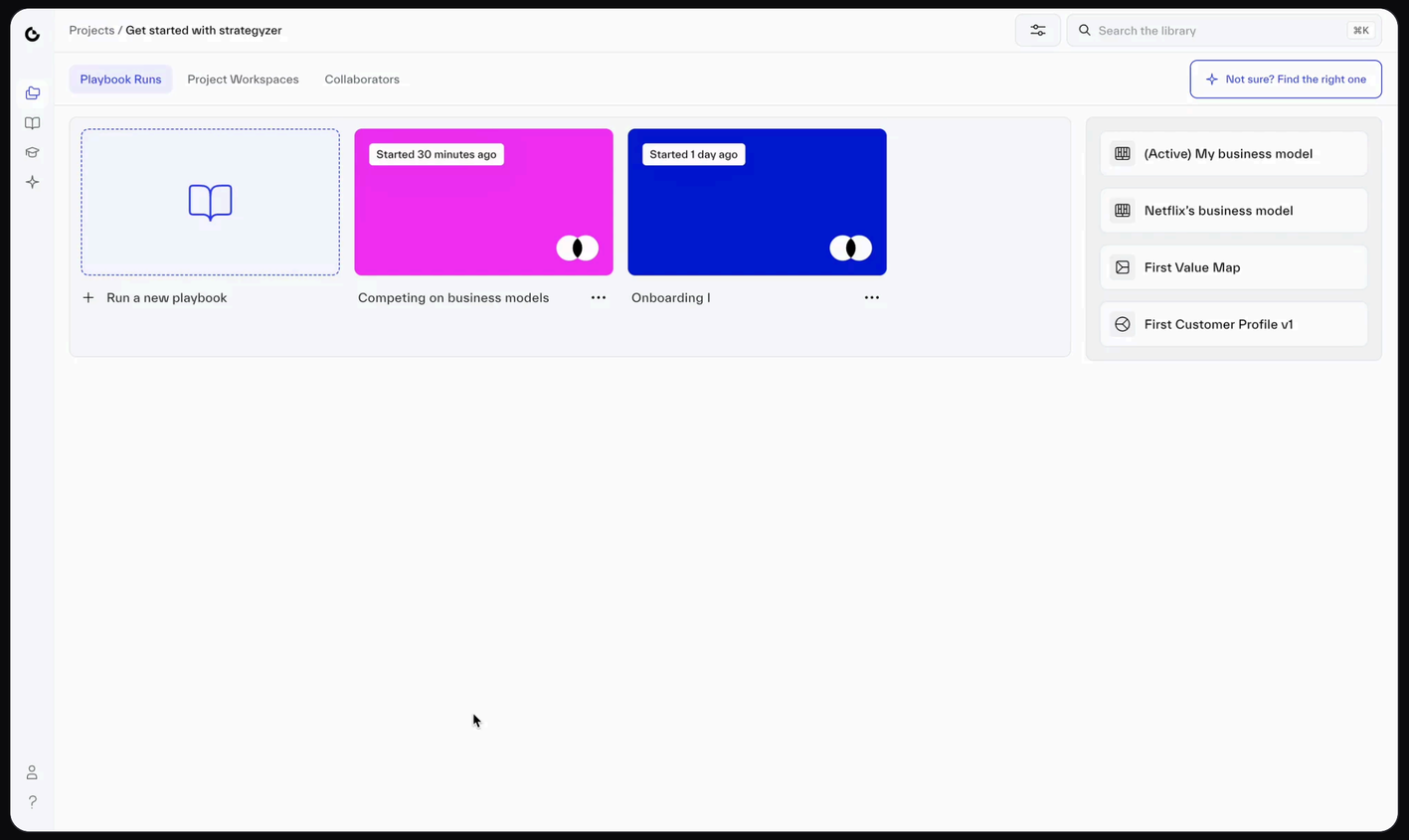
11 · DESIGN · WHEN NOTHING FITS

The hardest call in the project was what to do when nothing fits. When there's no good match, the Recommender says so and shows the closest options side by side, instead of pretending one is right. Three smaller details build trust too. The panel keeps one height, because early versions grew and shrank with every answer and felt jumpy. You can click any earlier answer to edit it without starting over. And if none of the options fit, people pick "Something else" and type their situation. AI reads it and finds the closest playbooks from the same map, so it only suggests real ones, and it explains its pick in plain language. There's no fake thinking either. Questions appear instantly, with a short pause only before the recommendation.

FROM STUCK TO STARTED

about 15 seconds

- STUCK
- QUESTION 1
- QUESTION 2
- QUESTION 3
- STARTED

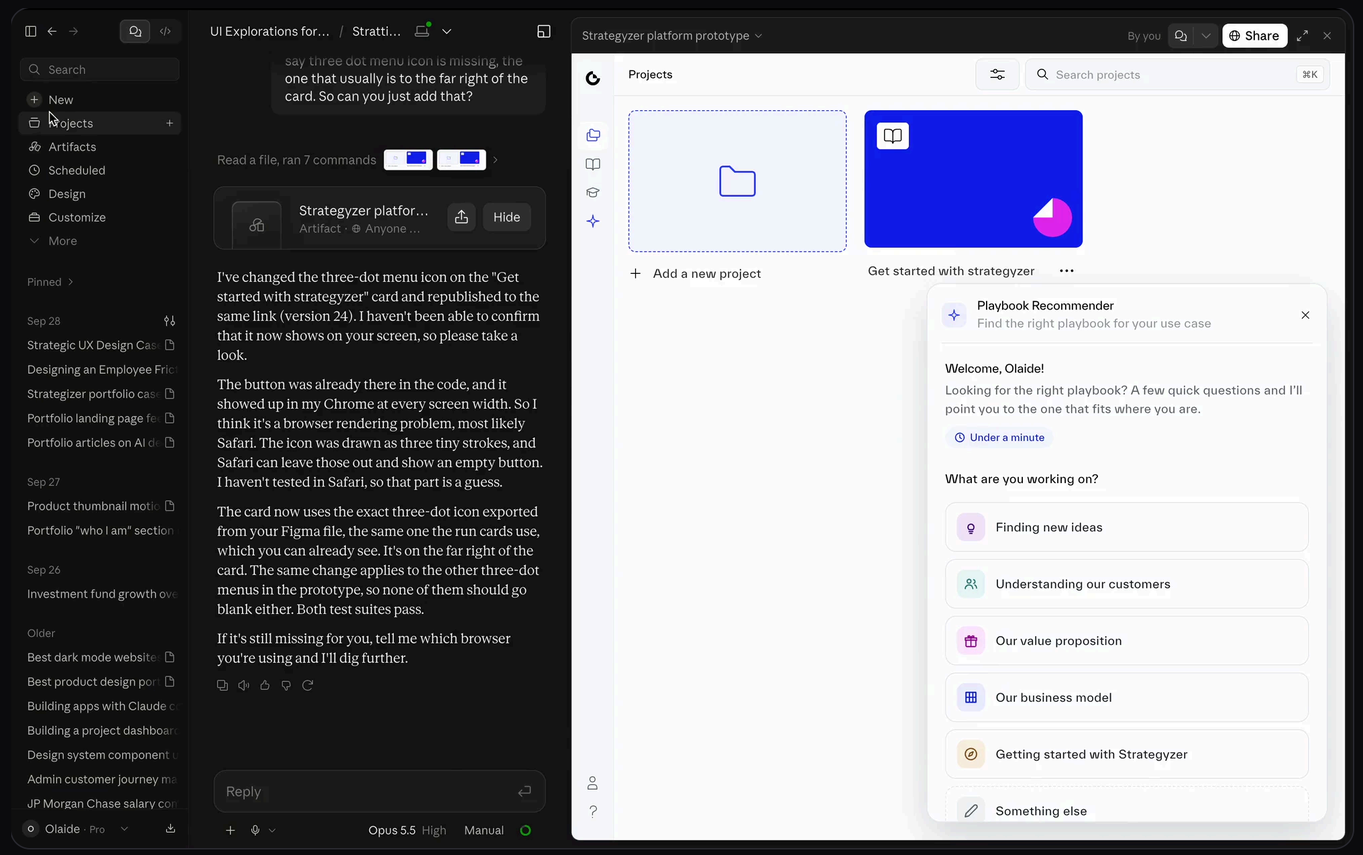


One click on Add to this project, and the playbook starts.

12 · DESIGN · FROM STUCK TO STARTED

A recommendation is only useful if people act on it. Inside a project, one click on "Add to this project" adds the playbook and starts it. In the library, the results filter what's shown to the recommended playbooks. From stuck to started takes about fifteen seconds, and that's the whole point of the project.

Tested on the real product, shipped as it was.



My conversation with Claude on the left, the working front end on the right.

about **24**

test sessions with coaches, customer teams and customers

ME	The front end, built in code with Claude
OUR ENGINEER	Data, tracking and the platform connection

The team now works at least twice as fast.

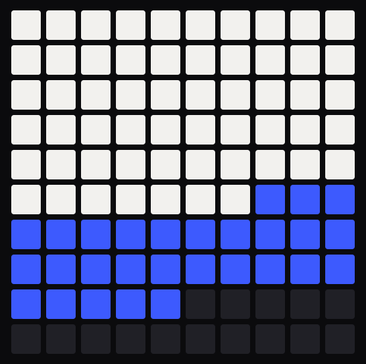
13 · DESIGN · TESTED AND BUILT IN CODE

Because I built it in code, people used the real thing instead of reacting to pictures of it. We ran about 24 sessions with coaches, customer teams and customers, about eight each. The biggest change was rewriting the questions so they were easier to understand, and so no one worried about picking the wrong answer. I designed this in code, not Figma. I built the front end myself with Claude on FondUI, and that code went straight into the product with no handover and no rebuild. Our engineer built everything behind it, which means data, tracking and connecting it to the rest of the platform. Automated tests clicked through every step and caught things that looked right but didn't work. Research took one to two weeks, the assistant prototype a few days, the question map two days, the Recommender three weeks to build, test and refine, and launch about a week and a half. About six weeks in total. The team now works at least twice as fast.

Fixing the first step moved every number that mattered.

Four months of data, before and after launch.

GETTING STARTED

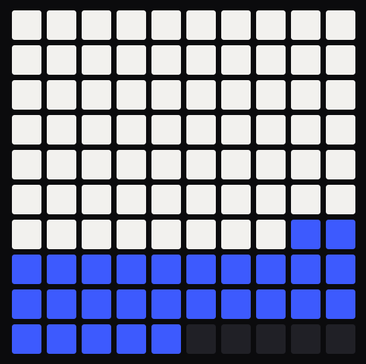


85%

was **57%**

of new customers start a project and a playbook

SATISFACTION

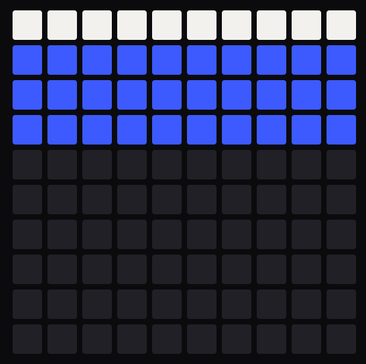


95%

was **68%**

from surveys and our customer success team

COMING BACK · 4×



40%

was **about 10%**

return within 30 days, most of them weekly

CANCELLED, THEN RETURNED



about 18%

after the release email

of cancelled customers came back to try it within two weeks

How we measured: product data for getting started and coming back, customer surveys and feedback for satisfaction

14 · IMPACT · RESULTS

We measured over four months, comparing the months before and after launch. Product data for getting started and coming back, customer surveys and the customer success team for satisfaction. New customers starting a project and a playbook went from 57% to 85%. Satisfaction went from 68% to 95%. People returning within 30 days went from about 10% to 40%, four times as many, and most come back weekly. That's the one that says the most about the design. With the right playbook from the start, people had a reason to return. And about 18% of customers who had cancelled came back to try the Recommender within two weeks of the release email. These results belong to the product and the team.

Next, the full assistant.

I've recommended building Strattie AI to help at every step after the first. It's on the roadmap for next year, and it can reuse the question map.



Shipping one focused thing first didn't shrink the vision. It made the case for it.

15 · IMPACT · WHAT'S NEXT

The Recommender fixes the first step. Next, I've recommended building Strattie AI, the assistant I prototyped at the start, to help at every step after that. It's on the roadmap for the next year, and it isn't live yet. It has a head start, with proof that guidance works, a question map it can reuse, real examples of how customers describe their problems, and a working prototype. Shipping one focused thing first didn't shrink the vision. It made the case for it.